

Ξενοκλῆς ὁ πρεσβύτερος Ἀθηναῖος

Xenocles the Elder and the Lament of Alcmena

eul_aid: eba

Period: *Κλασική* [Classical](#)
Dialect: *Δράμα Ἀττικόν* [Attic Drama](#)
Domain: *Δρᾶμα* [Drama](#)
Format: *Ἑμμετρος* [Verse](#)

Xenocles the Elder of Athens was a 5th-century BCE Athenian tragic poet. He was the son of the tragedian Carcinus I and a member of a prominent family of dramatists from Thoricus. He is historically noted for his victory in the tragic competition at the City Dionysia in 415 BCE, where he defeated Euripides, who presented a trilogy including the Trojan Women. He is sometimes distinguished from a later namesake, possibly his grandson, known as Xenocles the Younger.

No specific play titles by Xenocles the Elder survive. His victory in 415 BCE confirms he produced a full tetralogy of three tragedies and a satyr play, but the names of these works are lost.

His primary significance lies in his familial context and his notable victory over Euripides, which illustrates the variable nature of theatrical judging in classical Athens. His critical reputation was modest. Aristotle references a Xenocles, likely the Elder, in the Poetics as a poet whom nobody would dream of comparing with the great masters.

Works (1)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ τοῦ Ἀλκμήνης Θρήνου](#) · [Fragments on Alcmena's Lament](#) · 3 passages